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Moving and shaking: JWW Global Soul Award, Matisyahu, Netiya and more

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Jewish World Watch (JWW) awarded its 2015 Global Soul Award to the Katzburg Gabriel family on Nov. 18 during its annual gala event, held at UCLA Royce Hall.

"We look forward to working with you for the furtherance of this humanitarian mission," Stuart Gabriel said upon receiving the award. The Katzburg Gabriel family includes Gabriel and wife Judith Katzburg as well as their adult sons, Jesse and Oren Gabriel. According to JWW materials provided to the Journal, Stuart is a longstanding member of the JWW board of directors; Judith is a nurse and health services researcher; Jesse is involved with the organization's annual Walk to End Genocide; and Oren serves on the board of JWW.

Established by the late Valley Beth Shalom Rabbi Harold Schulweis in 2004, JWW aims to prevent mass atrocities in regions including Sudan, the Democratic Republic of Congo and elsewhere around the world. Recent initiatives include raising funds on behalf of refugees fleeing war-torn Syria.

The evening raised approximately $400,000, according to Janice Kamenir-Reznick, JWW co-founder and president, and drew approximately 400 community members, including Valley Beth Shalom Rabbi Ed Feinstein and his wife, Nina.

The event's honorary co-chairs included the Feinsteins, Ada and Jim Horwich, Alisa and Kevin Ratner, and May and Richard Ziman.

The evening featured a concert by avant-garde foursome Kronos Quartet and wrapped with a performance by Valley Beth Shalom Cantor Phil Baron.

Reggae artist Matisyahu reaffirmed support for Israel at a Friends of ELNET: European Leadership Network gala Nov. 17 at the Skirball Cultural Center.

A Nov. 17 Friends of ELNET: European Leadership Network fundraiser at the Skirball Cultural Center drew (from left) performer Matisyahu; Aaron Dugan, Matisyahu's guitarist; and Larry Hochberg, co-founder and chairman at ELNET, a European Israel advocacy organization. Photo by Ryan Torok

"Hopefully we can do more to show our support for Israel and our love for Israel," Matisyahu said, addressing approximately 150 attendees at the evening of cocktails, dinner, live music by Matisyahu, guitarist Aaron Dugan and more.

The event raised approximately $500,000 for ELNET, according to Jonathan Boyer, director of the California office of Friends of ELNET.

Matisyahu performed "One Day," "Jerusalem" and more at the stripped-down concert. Joined by longtime collaborator Dugan, Matisyahu fielded requests from the crowd and told stories between songs. Following his set, he lingered and posed for photographs with audience members, including businessman and philanthropist Stanley Black, Occidental College history professor Maryanne Horowitz and others.

Prior to the performance, Eran Etzion, executive director of the Forum of Strategic Dialogue, delivered a keynote lecture. Spotlighting the European financial crisis, the Russian invasion of Ukraine, the Syrian refugee crisis and the

recent terrorist attack in Paris, he said upheaval in Europe makes the work of ELNET, a European Israel advocacy organization, more necessary than ever.

The organization had a victory this past summer when a music festival in Spain featuring Matisyahu sought a statement of support of the Palestinians from Matisyahu and made his appearance contingent on him doing so. With the help of ELNET, Matisyahu performed as planned without acquiescing to the demands of the festival organizers.

Event committee members were Black; Larry Hochberg and his wife, Sue; Tricia and Tom Corby; Yvette and Eric Edidin; Rhonda and Joseph Feinberg; Ada and Jim Horwich; Eve Kurtin; and Wendy and Ken Ruby.

"We empower pro-Israel Europeans to be effective,"

Hochberg, co-founder and chairman at ELNET, said. "The Matisyahu experience shows what can be done if things are coordinated and focused."

A Netiya gardening and education event on Nov. 15 at New Horizon School Pasadena drew 65 attendees from the Jewish, Muslim, Christian and Buddhist communities who together planted 14 fruit trees in an urban orchard, according to Devorah Brous, executive director of Netiya.

An interfaith gardening event organized by agriculture group Netiya drew (from left) Barbara Williams, Stacey Inal, Cindy Roy, Leigh Adams, Karen Young, Yonathan Levenbach, Devorah Brous, Amira Al-Sarraf, Tahereh Sheerazie, Jane El Farra, Nahid Ansari and Lisa Friedman. Photo courtesy of Netiya

It was the 15th urban orchard planted by Netiya, according to the Netiya Facebook page.

Attendees included Amira Al-Sarraf, head of school at New Horizon School, a day school serving the American-Muslim community; the Rev. Jeff Utter of All Paths Divinity School; and others. The two were among those who discussed "mystical traditions around tree planting" prior to the gardening in the orchard, according to the Facebook page.

Netiya, founded in 2010, is a Jewish network dedicated to advancing urban agriculture in religious institutions, nonprofits and schools across Los Angeles.

A slew of diverse religious leaders, including Temple Ramat Zion Rabbi Ahud Sela, Los Angeles Police Department Chaplain Ken Crawford and others, turned out at a Nov. 23 Thanksgiving-inspired interfaith service at Temple Ramat Zion in Northridge.

From left: Temple Ramat Zion Cantor Daniel Friedman, the Rev. Ramon Valera of Our Lady of Lourdes, the Rev. Joseph Choi of Northridge United Methodist Church, Mufti Ibrahim Qureshi of Islamic Center of Northridge, Temple Ramat Zion Rabbi Ahud Sela, the Rev. Karen Murata of Northridge United Methodist Church and Father David Loftus of Our Lady of Lourdes. Photo by Joe Morchy

In total, the event attracted "over 600 people from all faiths," according to Michele Nachum, a spokeswoman for Temple Ramat Zion.

Additional participants at the evening gathering included Temple Ramat Zion Cantor Daniel Friedman; Northridge United Methodist Church Senior Pastor the Rev. Joseph Choi and Associate Pastor the Rev. Karen Murata; Islamic Center of Northridge Mufti Ibrahim Qureshi; and Father David Loftus of Our Lady of Lourdes Parish School.

Described as an "interfaith service in Northridge to build community and understanding," the event also featured an

interfaith choir composed of members of Temple Ramat Zion, United Methodist Church and Our Lady of Lourdes. Conservative synagogue Temple Ramat Zion participates in an interfaith Thanksgiving event every year.

Article updated Jan. 21, 2016: The Journal mistakenly reported the Friends of ELNET event raised approximately $50,000, not $500,000.

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